

One had time, the other had moments that stopped it



Two sides of the same coin: Kane Williamson and Ben Stokes, two defining figures of the modern era, embodied contrasting approaches to the game. GETTYIMAGES

As **Kane Williamson and Ben Stokes** step away from international cricket, a look at two contrasting personalities who shaped the modern game in their own distinct ways.

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In the 2023 Christchurch Test against Sri Lanka, New Zealand needed 285 on the final day. Kane Williamson kept the host in the hunt, and it eventually came down to eight runs off the final over.

Williamson, already past his 27th Test century, brought the equation down to one off the last ball. He missed the hook but set off immediately, diving at the non-striker's end and just making his ground as the ball hit the stumps.

Emotions erupted all around him as his batting partner, Neil Wagner, sprinted in to embrace him, while the Sri Lankans had their hands on their knees in disbelief. Despite all the chaos, Williamson gave little away.

He lay face down on the pitch for a moment before standing up to shake hands with the opposition, looking almost as surprised as they were.

It was vintage Williamson: an unflustered smile and no attempt to make the moment about himself. That modesty and simplicity defined him throughout his career. It was also a trait that had come to define New Zealand cricket itself: the nice guys.

It was much the same at the 2019 World Cup Final at Lord's, when New Zealand fell a boundary short of the title against England. Amid the overthrows and the Super Over, Williamson barely flinched and accepted the heartbreak with grace.

At the other end of that final stood Ben Stokes. It was his unbeaten 84 that turned the game for England that day. A month later at

Headingley, with England staring at defeat against Australia, Stokes produced one of Test cricket's most memorable knocks: an unbeaten 135 to chase down 359. He then roared to the crowd, arms aloft, soaking in the theatre of it all.

Opposite ends of the spectrum

Where Williamson often blended into the background, Stokes always seemed to pull the spotlight towards him. That, perhaps, was the essence of their careers.

For the better part of the last decade, the duo stood at opposite ends of sport's emotional spectrum, yet somehow arrived at the same destination: indispensable to their teams and defining figures of the modern era.

Williamson made his debut in 2010 and announced himself with a